

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

Digital Registration, Indexing, Examination, Licensing, and Compliance Operations

Nursing Council of The Bahamas

Draft version 1.0 | July 2026 | Prepared for operational rollout and Council review

Document purpose

This SOP establishes a practical operating standard for moving Council registration, licensing, examination, indexing, profile management, and compliance workflows from paper-based handling into a controlled digital environment.

Status: Draft for internal review. Fee enforcement, reactivation rules, APN/specialist implementation, and any statutory interpretations must be confirmed through Council approval and legal consultation before final adoption.

Document Control

Field	Details
SOP title	Digital Registration, Indexing, Examination, Licensing, and Compliance Operations
SOP number	NCB-SOP-OPS-001
Owner	Registrar, Nursing Council of The Bahamas
Applies to	Council staff, authorized reviewers, Council members when assigned validation tasks, technical support personnel, nurses, applicants, employers, and training institutions interacting with the digital platform
Effective date	To be assigned after Council approval
Review cycle	At least annually and after the first digital rollout cycle
Prepared for	Operational transition from paper-based workflows to digital registration and licensing operations
Version	Draft 1.0

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1. Purpose and Scope

The purpose of this SOP is to define the standard operating process for Council activities that are being transitioned from informal or paper-based handling into the Nursing Council digital platform. It is designed to preserve the Council's existing operational logic while creating clearer ownership, status tracking, auditability, and data security.

This SOP applies to registration, indexing, examination scheduling, licensing, renewal, reactivation, compliance tracking, foreign registration, complaints intake, payments, document verification, profile management, employer data capture, and support queries.

Scope note

This SOP is a master operating SOP. Separate process-specific SOPs may be issued under it for registration, indexing, examination, licensing, foreign registration, complaints, payments, and data verification.

2. Operating Principles

- The system must fit Council workflows instead of forcing staff into unfamiliar steps without operational reason.
- Every application, profile update, document review, payment event, examination action, complaint, and decision must have an owner and traceable status.
- Nurse-facing profiles may allow login and document uploads, but internal Council files must remain restricted and not visible to nurses.
- Existing nurses and new applicants must be supported through flexible registration tracks.
- Foreign registration must remain a separate workflow because translation, transcription, and international credential review may be required.
- Examination and education cycles must be dynamic because training institutions do not always follow fixed calendars.
- Communication must begin early enough for nurses, employers, and institutions to understand digital licensing requirements before enforcement begins.
- Policy matters that are not finalized must be treated as pending until Council approval and legal consultation are completed.

3. Authority and References

This SOP should be read together with the Nursing Act, applicable regulations, Council policies and bylaws, approved Council decisions, committee terms of reference, data protection requirements, confidentiality rules, records management requirements, payment policies, and any applicable Ministry of Health or Government of The Bahamas directives.

Legal alignment required

Compliance fees, back-fee recovery, license reactivation rules, and specialty licensing implementation must be reviewed against applicable law and formally approved before being enforced.

4. Definitions

Term	Definition
Applicant	A person applying for registration, examination, licensing, reactivation, or another Council service.

Term	Definition
Existing nurse	A nurse already known to Council records whose paper or legacy file must be linked to a digital profile.
Indexing	The process of reviewing, digitizing, organizing, and linking existing paper or legacy records to the correct digital profile.
Digital profile	The nurse or applicant record in the platform, including identity, license number, contact details, employer information, documents, status history, and approved credentials.
Restricted Council file	An internal document, note, flag, complaint, or review item visible only to authorized Council users.
Foreign registration	Registration involving international training, credentials, transcripts, translations, or verification from outside The Bahamas.
Compliance fee	A Council-approved fee intended to support timely renewal compliance. It must be legally reviewed before enforcement.
Reactivation	The process for restoring a license or profile after non-renewal, absence from local practice, or return from practice abroad.

5. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Primary responsibilities
Registrar	Owns implementation, resolves escalations, approves exceptional handling, confirms policy interpretation, and reports significant matters to Council.
Administrative staff	Receive submissions, answer queries, log files, review completeness, update records, and issue standard communications.
Data digitization lead	Assesses existing files, pre-populates profile data, updates contact and registration records, and flags records needing review.
Verification officer	Reviews identity, license number, documents, name changes, specialty certificates, employer information, and data-linking exceptions.
Examination officer	Creates examination cycles, manages candidate deadlines, tracks candidate eligibility, and records results or status changes.
Licensing officer	Processes renewal, digital license issuance, reactivation, back-fee review, compliance status, and specialty license handling.
Council or board	Approves policies and may support limited validation tasks where assigned, recognizing member availability and digital-literacy constraints.
Technical support	Supports staff and users, resolves platform access issues, and escalates system defects or data issues.
Nurse or applicant	Submits accurate information, uploads required documents, maintains contact and employer details, and responds to Council requests.

6. Access Control and Confidentiality

Access must be role-based and limited to the minimum information needed for each user to perform assigned duties. Role levels must support read-only access, verification access, edit access, approval access, and restricted access for confidential flags or sensitive Council files.

Access level	Typical permissions
Read-only	View assigned records and public status information. No edits or approvals.
Verification	Review submitted documents and mark verification outcomes.
Edit	Update contact details, employer records, document status, notes, and assigned workflow fields.
Approval	Approve registration, licensing, renewal, reactivation, examination eligibility, or escalated records within delegated authority.
Restricted	View confidential flags, internal Council files, complaints, disciplinary items, and sensitive notes.

Confidentiality rule

Council-uploaded documents, internal notes, complaint records, flags, and sensitive review material must not be visible to nurses unless formally approved for disclosure.

7. Core Workflow Standard

The following workflow applies to all digital operational processes unless a process-specific SOP provides a more detailed rule.

1. Receive the submission or request through the platform, website form, email, phone, in-person intake, or an authorized internal channel.
2. Classify the request type as registration, indexing, examination, licensing, renewal, reactivation, foreign registration, complaint, name change, employer update, specialty update, payment issue, or general query.
3. Search for an existing profile using license number, registered name, date of birth, contact details, file number, or specialty license number.
4. Create a new profile only when no reliable existing profile can be linked.
5. Assign an owner and status, then record the date received and any immediate missing requirements.
6. Verify required information and documents based on the workflow category.
7. Request missing information in writing and record the deadline for response.
8. Escalate high-risk, unusual, legally sensitive, or policy-dependent matters to the Registrar or Council.
9. Record the decision, decision maker, date, supporting notes, and documents reviewed.
10. Notify the applicant, nurse, employer, or institution using the approved communication channel.
11. Update records and close the file, or assign a follow-up date for open matters.

8. Indexing and Digitization of Existing Files

8.1 Objective

The objective of indexing is to move existing paper or legacy files into the digital environment without losing continuity of registration history, license numbers, contact details, specialty records, or employer information.

8.2 Procedure

1. Collect existing paper or legacy records by file group, registration category, or priority batch.
2. Review the file for license number, registered name, current or last known contact information, registration status, specialty details, employer information, and documents requiring verification.
3. Create or update the digital profile using the most reliable Council-held data.

4. Flag unclear records, duplicate records, missing identifiers, name mismatch issues, or documents requiring Registrar review.
5. Do not expose scanned internal Council files to the nurse profile unless approved for nurse-facing use.
6. Record the indexing officer, date indexed, source file type, and unresolved issues.

8.3 Minimum data fields

- License number or legacy file number
- Name as registered
- Registration category
- Contact details, if available
- Current or last known employer
- Specialty license or certification, if available
- Verification notes and unresolved flags

9. Registration Workflows

9.1 Registration tracks

The platform must support multiple registration tracks because the Council must handle existing nurses, new local applicants, new graduates, examination candidates, foreign-trained applicants, and nurses returning to practice.

Track	Operational handling
Existing nurse platform registration	Link to existing file or license number, verify core identity, update contact details, and issue digital license according to rollout policy.
New registration	Create applicant profile, collect required documents, verify eligibility, assign status, and route for review or approval.
Graduate or examination-linked registration	Coordinate with the relevant training institution and examination cycle. Deadlines must remain dynamic.
Foreign registration	Route separately for credential, transcript, translation, and international verification review.
Returning nurse or reactivation	Review prior status, absence period, unpaid fees if applicable, and Council-approved reactivation requirements.

9.2 Procedure

1. Applicant creates or updates a digital profile.
2. System collects required registration type and supporting documents.
3. Staff review for completeness and determine whether the applicant is an existing nurse, new applicant, exam-linked candidate, foreign applicant, or reactivation case.
4. Officer verifies license number and registered name when an existing record is claimed.
5. Incomplete files are returned with clear instructions and deadlines.
6. Complete files are routed for verification, Registrar review, committee review, or Council decision according to the registration track.
7. Decision is recorded and communicated to the applicant.

10. Examination Scheduling and Candidate Processing

10.1 Scheduling principle

The Council does not operate under a fixed examination calendar because education programs and institutional cycles vary. May-June and December may remain target periods, but the system must allow deadlines and cycles to be created dynamically.

10.2 Procedure

1. Examination officer creates a proposed examination cycle with application opening date, deadline, target examination window, eligible institution or program group, and required documents.
2. Registrar reviews and approves the cycle parameters before publication.
3. Training institutions and candidates are notified through website, email, employer or institution channels, and social media where appropriate.
4. Candidate submissions are checked for completeness and eligibility.
5. Late, incomplete, or irregular submissions are flagged for review according to Council policy.
6. Approved candidate lists are locked before examination administration.
7. Results or status outcomes are recorded in the candidate profile and linked to next registration or licensing steps.

Flexible deadline rule

The platform must allow Council staff to set registration deadlines, education cycles, and examination windows without hard-coded dates.

11. Licensing, Renewal, Reactivation, and Compliance

11.1 Digital license rollout

During initial adoption, platform registration may include a free digital license for the upcoming year to encourage nurse participation and reduce rollout friction. The start of fee enforcement must be communicated early and clearly.

11.2 Renewal procedure

1. Nurse logs into the platform and reviews profile details.
2. Nurse updates contact details, employer information, and optional specialty certificates.
3. System identifies the appropriate license or highest specialty renewal level.
4. Nurse submits renewal request and payment when applicable.
5. Licensing officer verifies payment, renewal eligibility, and any unresolved compliance flags.
6. Officer approves, defers, or escalates the renewal.
7. Approved digital license is issued and license verification status is updated.

11.3 Non-renewal and reactivation

Nurses who fail to renew may be required to pay outstanding back fees before receiving a new license, subject to Council policy and legal confirmation. Nurses returning from practice abroad may be handled under a standard reactivation fee or process once formally approved.

11.4 Specialty licensing

Nurses may hold multiple license numbers for specialties such as midwifery and community health nursing. Renewal should occur at the highest applicable specialty level. APNs and clinical nurse specialists should be integrated when regulations are finalized.

12. Foreign Registration

Foreign registration must be treated as a separate workflow because document translation, transcript review, international verification, registration equivalency, and policy interpretation may be required.

1. Applicant selects foreign registration track and submits required identity, education, registration, transcript, and credential documents.
2. Staff confirm whether translation or transcription is required.
3. Verification officer reviews authenticity and completeness of international documentation.
4. Registrar determines whether committee, Council, legal, or external credential review is required.
5. Applicant is notified of missing items, additional verification requirements, or decision outcome.
6. Approved foreign applicants are routed to the appropriate registration, examination, or licensing step.

Restriction

Foreign registration files should not be merged into the general registration workflow until foreign-specific checks have been completed or waived by authorized approval.

13. Data Verification and Name Changes

13.1 Profile linking

Profiles should be linked to existing records using the strongest available identifiers, including license number, name as registered, date of birth, legacy file number, and specialty license number. Records with uncertain matches must be flagged instead of force-linked.

13.2 Name change rule

For legal name changes, the passport is the recognized proof of the updated legal name. Marriage certificates alone should not be accepted as sufficient proof if the passport has not been updated. Name changes must be reviewed and approved by Council staff before the registered name is changed.

13.3 Procedure

1. Nurse submits name change request through profile or approved channel.
2. Nurse provides current license number and name as registered.
3. Nurse uploads passport showing the updated legal name.
4. Verification officer reviews the request and compares it to existing Council records.
5. If approved, officer updates the profile and records the decision note.
6. If rejected or incomplete, officer notifies the nurse with the reason and required corrective action.

14. Employer and Workforce Data

The digital platform should capture where nurses work to support workforce mapping, compliance tracking, and regulatory oversight. Nurses may have a primary workplace and additional workplaces.

1. System presents a starter employer list beginning with major hospitals, institutions, and large employers.
2. Nurse selects primary employer and may add additional workplaces.
3. Nurse may request addition of smaller, private, or island-based employers not already listed.
4. Staff review new employer entries to prevent duplicates and maintain clean reporting data.
5. Employer data is used for workforce mapping, stakeholder engagement, compliance follow-up, and reporting.

15. Complaints and Public Submissions

The website should clearly display the complaints process and provide a complaint submission form. Each complaint must generate a unique complaint number for tracking.

1. Complaint is submitted through the approved website form or official intake channel.
2. System generates a unique complaint number.
3. Administrative staff logs the complaint and checks for completeness.
4. Sensitive complaint details are restricted to authorized users only.
5. Registrar reviews the complaint or assigns it for preliminary assessment.
6. Complaint is routed according to Council policy, including disciplinary or legal pathways where required.
7. Complainant receives acknowledgement and appropriate status communication, subject to confidentiality limits.

16. Payments and License Verification

The Council intends to integrate online payments, including RBC options, to streamline registration, licensing, renewal, reactivation, agency registration, and other fee-based services. Digital license verification should allow employers and the public to confirm license status through approved channels.

16.1 Payment handling

1. System calculates applicable fee based on service type and approved fee policy.
2. User submits payment through the approved payment method once available.
3. Payment status is recorded in the profile or transaction record.
4. Staff reconcile exceptions, failed payments, duplicate payments, and manual payments.
5. No license or certificate should be issued until required payment status is confirmed unless authorized by policy.

16.2 Digital license verification

- Verification should confirm active status without exposing confidential profile details.
- Verification records should be time-stamped.
- Government domain use should be pursued if approved to improve credibility and public trust.

17. Communications and Stakeholder Engagement

The website is the core communication tool and should be supported by social media, press releases, employer notices, institution notices, and direct stakeholder engagement. Communication must be proactive before platform adoption, license renewal, examination cycles, and compliance enforcement.

Audience	Message focus
Nurses	Profile creation, document upload, license renewal, employer updates, digital license access, deadlines, and support channels.
Employers	Verification process, staff registration drives, license compliance expectations, and workforce data accuracy.
Training institutions	Examination cycles, candidate deadlines, registration requirements, and institutional data coordination.
Board and Council members	Policy decisions, validation support opportunities, communication support, and digital literacy needs.
Public	Council role, complaints process, license verification, standards, and contact information.

Rollout timing

Preliminary stakeholder engagement should begin before public campaigns. Registration drives and communication campaigns should be coordinated around the November-December rollout period and relevant examination cycles.

18. Support Queries and Calls

Support functions must be assigned clear ownership so staff can handle calls, email, portal queries, profile issues, document questions, and employer or institution questions consistently.

1. Receive query and classify by topic.
2. Confirm caller or requester identity before discussing personal record information.
3. Answer standard questions using approved scripts or published guidance.
4. Create a support note when the query affects a record, deadline, document, payment, or status.
5. Escalate technical problems, sensitive matters, policy questions, or complaints to the assigned owner.
6. Close the query only after response or escalation has been recorded.

19. Quality Assurance and Reporting

The Registrar or assigned supervisor should review sample records regularly during the rollout and after each major cycle. Quality checks should confirm completeness, correct status, role-based access, decision documentation, payment handling, duplicate prevention, and data accuracy.

- Weekly review during active rollout or registration drives.
- Monthly review once operations stabilize.
- Cycle review after examination, renewal, or major registration periods.
- Immediate review after any data breach, repeated complaint, payment issue, or system defect.

Metric	Purpose
Profiles created	Measures adoption and progress toward all nurses being on the platform.
Profiles verified	Measures data integrity and readiness for licensing enforcement.
Incomplete applications	Identifies communication gaps and common missing documents.
Renewals completed	Tracks compliance and license status.
Employer records added	Supports workforce mapping and duplicate control.
Support queries	Identifies staff capacity needs and training opportunities.

20. Exceptions, Escalation, Review, and Approval

20.1 Escalation triggers

- Foreign credentials, translation, or transcript uncertainty.
- Name mismatch or profile linking uncertainty.
- Duplicate license number or duplicate identity match.
- Sensitive complaint or disciplinary concern.
- Unpaid renewal, back-fee, reactivation, or compliance dispute.

- Policy not yet approved or requiring legal interpretation.
- System error affecting records, payments, licenses, or verification.

20.2 SOP review

This SOP must be reviewed after the first digital rollout cycle and at least annually thereafter. It must also be reviewed when Council policy, legislation, staffing, platform functionality, payment integration, examination operations, or license categories change.

20.3 Approval

Name	Role	Signature	Date
[Insert name]	Prepared by		
[Insert name]	Reviewed by Registrar		
[Insert name]	Reviewed by legal/policy advisor, if required		
[Insert name]	Approved by Council/Chairperson		

Appendix A: Standard Status Values

Status	Use
Received	Submission has been received but not yet reviewed.
Incomplete	Required information or documents are missing.
Awaiting applicant	Council has requested information and is waiting for the nurse or applicant.
Under review	Assigned officer is reviewing the file.
Pending verification	Document, identity, payment, credential, or profile link must be verified.
Escalated	Matter has been referred to Registrar, Council, legal, committee, or technical support.
Approved	Request has been approved.
Approved with conditions	Approval depends on stated conditions or follow-up items.
Deferred	Decision has been postponed pending additional information, policy, or Council direction.
Rejected	Request has been denied and reason recorded.
Closed	Workflow is complete and no further action is pending.

Appendix B: Target Timelines

Activity	Target timeline
Acknowledge submission	Within 2 business days where possible.
Preliminary completeness review	Within 5 business days for routine files.
Missing information request	Within 3 business days after identifying gap.
Routine registration review	Within 10-20 business days after file is complete.
Foreign registration review	Timeline to be determined by credential verification and translation requirements.
Complaint acknowledgement	Within 2 business days where possible.
System issue escalation	Same business day for license, payment, or verification-impacting defects.

Appendix C: SOP Suite To Develop Under This Master SOP

SOP number	SOP title
NCB-SOP-REG-001	New and Existing Nurse Registration
NCB-SOP-IDX-001	Indexing and Digitization of Existing Files
NCB-SOP-EXAM-001	Examination Scheduling and Candidate Processing
NCB-SOP-LIC-001	Licensing, Renewal, Reactivation, and Compliance Fees
NCB-SOP-FRN-001	Foreign Registration and Credential Review

SOP number	SOP title
NCB-SOP-DATA-001	Name Change, Profile Linking, and Data Verification
NCB-SOP-COMP-001	Complaint Submission, Tracking, and Review
NCB-SOP-PAY-001	Online Payments, Receipts, and License Verification
NCB-SOP-COMMS-001	Stakeholder Communications and Registration Drives

Appendix D: Implementation Notes From Project Scope

- Current staff capacity is limited; digital rollout should include at least one technically strong support resource.
- Board members may assist with limited validation tasks but should not be assumed to carry routine operational workload.
- System testing with a pool of nurses should validate profile creation, data accuracy, document upload, and license workflow readiness.
- Website content should include mission, vision, core values, responsibilities, history, standards, code of ethics, complaints process, forms, contact information, and portal links.
- AI-generated media placeholders should be replaced over time with authentic Council event and community images where available.